

Donor behavior of the Romanian Diaspora in the USA

– an analysis commissioned by RUF –

As disposable income increased by 4.3 percent compared to 2018 the share of individual giving in the USA total giving reached the largest dollar total to date in 2019. Increasing by 4.2% compared to 2018, giving by individuals totaled an estimated \$309.66 billion¹. It accounted for 69% out of the total of \$449.64 billion that Americans have donated to charities in 2019. The largest recipients of charitable contributions continue to be religious organizations, receiving 29% of the total giving in 2019².

These figures indicate the sheer magnitude and power of individual giving in America. However, studies on individual giving do not take into consideration ancestry or cultural heritage which can be an influencing factor when it comes to cross border giving, especially in the case of diasporas. This is also the case for the Romanian diaspora. According to the 2019 American Community Survey there are 251.700³ individuals living in the US that have reported Romanian ancestry. There is currently no overarching reliable information on the donor behavior of this group. In addition, previous studies have examined a limited subset of the diaspora (the Făgăraș diaspora⁴) using social network analysis and qualitative methods (interviews and focus groups), but there are currently no studies on the larger diaspora with regards to donor behavior.

In order to address this gap in knowledge that has both scientific and practical value, RUF intends to initiate a study similar to that developed by ARC in Romania, Trends in individual giving (2016). The study is aimed at understanding why people donate, or conversely, why they do not donate, what causes they support, what types of charities they fund, what needs to change for them to become donors or to increase their donations, and what types of community services they see as lacking and requiring attention on behalf of NGOs. In the context of Romanian diaspora in the US, additional relevant aspects include the strength of the connection to Romania and their communities of origin and their donor behavior in relation to causes in Romania.

¹ Compared to \$292.09 billion in 2018 - *Giving USA is Giving USA 2019: The Annual Report on Philanthropy for the Year 2018*, a publication of Giving USA Foundation, 2019, researched and written by the Indiana University Lilly Family School of Philanthropy.

² Takeaways from Giving USA 2020 – The Annual Report on Philanthropy-
<https://www.bkd.com/article/2020/07/takeaways-giving-usa-2020-annual-report-philanthropy>.

³ <https://data.census.gov/cedsci/table?q=ancestry&d=ACS%201-Year%20Estimates%20Detailed%20Tables&tid=ACSDT1Y2019.B04004&hidePreview=false>.

⁴ [Raport privind potențialul de implicare al diasporei în comunitățile din Țara Făgărașului.](#)

To achieve this, ARC proposes using the official figure of the Census, which – while most likely undercounts and underreports the number of individuals with Romanian heritage – combined with geographic distribution data can be used to develop a sample that can allow the analysis of the donor behavior among the Romanian Diaspora members across the USA. The constructed sample⁵ can then approximate the distribution of the diaspora across the US, ensuring that responses are not predominantly coming from one part or the other of the USA, as variation in giving may be possible within geographic areas, between 1st generation and 2nd generation Romanian Americans, time spent in the US, reason for emigration, and so on.

The minimum required sample size for the known population is 385⁶. The data will be collected using an online survey administered through SurveyMonkey to Romanians that are members of Romanian organizations / associations across the USA, or that are in contact with these organizations or the church. Questionnaire items will be based on ARC's 2016 study, adapted to the American context and the RUF's objectives. The analyses will be performed using SPSS statistical analysis software. The results will enable RUF to increase and improve its fundraising activities and to develop community programs that respond to the needs of the diaspora.

The insights from the quantitative data will be combined with results from qualitative analyses (interviews with key stakeholders / gatekeepers / knowledge holders, as well as focus groups with selected individuals). This will allow to 1)confirm findings from the quantitative analyses and increase the validity of the findings, 2)contextualize data, 3)add in depth understanding of the mechanisms behind behavior, and 4)provide additional rich information that can increase the utility of numerical data.

Costs associated with the study vary depending on the objectives of the study, the type of the desired sample (representative vs. approximating the population), data collection methods (CATI⁷ vs online surveys), whether data collection is performed by ARC or another entity, whether data cleaning / management is performed by ARC or another entity (e.g. US-based market research agency), whether data analysis / report development is performed by ARC or by another entity.

⁵ Another, more expensive and more laborious, option is generating a representative sample and contacting respondents using CATI, but the lack of a readily available sampling frame (list of individuals that can be contacted) makes this option impractical.

⁶ Calculated using $n_1 = n_0 / \{1 + [(n_0 - 1) / N]\}$, Where n_0 is the size of the sample required for an unknown population, n_1 is the size of the necessary sample size in the case of a finite population, while N is the size of the population (Fejes, 2016, based on Israel, 1992).

⁷ Computer assisted telephone interviewing.

Options

Option 1: Quantitative study (good option for large scale reliable and generalizable results)

1.a. Study design, sampling, data cleaning / management & analysis, report writing performed by ARC & partners. Data collection performed *with the aid of RUF*.

15000 EUR + VAT

1.b. Study design, sampling, report writing performed by ARC *& partners. Data collection performed *by RUF* with instrument provided by ARC. Data cleaning / management & analysis by ARC *& partners.

11000 EUR + VAT

Option 2: Mixed methods study (most comprehensive)

2.a. Study design & sampling developed by ARC . Interviews and focus groups conducted by ARC & Partners with the *aid of RUF*. Data collection / cleaning / management & analysis as well as report writing performed by ARC & partners.

17000 EUR + VAT

2.b. Study design, sampling, report writing performed by ARC *& partners. Data collection & interviews/focus groups performed *by RUF* with instruments provided by ARC. Data cleaning / management & analysis by ARC *& partners.

13000 EUR + VAT

Option 3: Qualitative study (good option with insights highly dependent on the quality of the focus groups and interviewees)

3.a. Study design developed by ARC. Interviews and focus groups conducted by ARC & Partners with the *aid of RUF*. Data cleaning / management & analysis as well as report writing performed by ARC & partners.

11000 EUR + VAT